Copyright Statement

The Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College has made a reasonable effort to secure permission from the interviewees to make these materials available to the public. Use of these materials by other parties is subject to the fair use doctrine in United States copyright law (Title 17, Chapter 1, section 107), which states that use by “reproduction in copies or phonorecords or by any other means specified by that section [106 and 106A], for purposes such as criticism, comment, news reporting, teaching (including multiple copies for classroom use), scholarship, or research, is not an infringement of copyright."

Any use that does not fall within fair use must be cleared with the rights holder. For assistance in contacting the rights holder please contact the Fillius Jazz Archive, Hamilton College, 198 College Hill Road, Clinton, NY 13323 (phone: 315-859-4071).

Frank Wess

Reedman Frank Wess is an important part of the Basie legacy. As half of the two tenor team in the reformed Basie band of the 50's, he was instrumental in propelling the group to its highest popularity. Born in Kansas City in 1922, Frank honed his craft with bands led by Lucky Millinder, Eddie Haywood and Billy Eckstine. From 1953-64 he teamed with Frank Foster and Marshall Royal to solidify the great Basie sax section. Basie also employed Frank's considerable arranging skills as well as his pioneering jazz work on the flute. After the Basie years he found steady work in New York studios while keeping a presence on the jazz scene with the New York Jazz Quartet and Dameronia. In recent years, Frank has co-led a group with Frank Foster, performed briefly with Woody Herman and has become a featured player at jazz fests and parties across the country.

Frank was interviewed by Monk Rowe and Michael Woods on May 29, 1995 aboard a jazz cruise in the Caribbean.

MW: We are on board the Royal Caribbean cruise line and we are filming the Jazz Archive series for Hamilton College. Our guest today is Frank Wess. Pleased to have you.

FW: Hello. Thank you.

MR: Pleased to have you here.

FW: My pleasure.

MW: I would like to ask you if you could relate to us just how you were involved, you were one of the first to involve the flute in the big band context and in a jazz improvisation context. Tell us about that.

MR: What led you to pick up that instrument as a jazz horn?

FW: Oh well that started years ago when I was in high school. My teacher, Henry L. Grant, who was also Duke Ellington's teacher and Billy Taylor, Dr. Billy Taylor and I studied with him. And he was the orchestra teacher you know. And he gave me a flute to take home you know. So I took it home and after fooling with it a while I realized that I couldn't do it without a teacher, you know. And at the time, you know I couldn't afford a teacher and there wasn't one available that I knew of. So I said I'll just let it rest until I can get to it you know. So at that time there was a fellow named Wayman Carver, who was in the Chick Webb orchestra. And he played with a group within the orchestra called the Little Chicks. And that inspired me to want to play the flute. Because he was the first that I know of to do it. So and he recorded a lot with Benny Carter and you know, the musicians that were recording at that time you know. So and then after I, well what happened actually I was studying the flute when I got a chance to study it under the GI bill I got a chance to go back to school and studied flute, so I did. And Basie evidently

was looking for a tenor player you know, so he kept calling and calling. He called for a couple of years and I told him I was doing something, you know, and I couldn't leave right then. So he just kept calling. Periodically he would call. And in the meantime I got a degree, a bachelor's degree in flute, and we got together and I joined Basie. Well the thing was at the time I mean, what made me go with him because actually I had quit the road five years before I joined Basie. You know I'd given up on the road because I first left home in 1939. So he said that, "Well Frank, I think I can give you more exposure than you've had," you know. So that's what made me join him. I said maybe that is what I need. So I went with him. Well Billy Eckstine had told him, you know, about me. Then when I got in the band, well Don Redman had asked him, "have you ever heard him play flute?" He say, "no." Said, "You ought to let him play flute." So Bas' told me, you know, "whatever solos you have, you know, on tenor, whatever you've got, if you want to play it on flute, just go ahead and do it." So that's how that came about. And I'd been playing flute for a while.

MW: What was the audience response like? Did they like it?

FW: Oh, yeah, yeah. Well I mean it was different, you know, 'cause wasn't nobody really doing that. Sam Most was playing, and Jerome Richardson was playing, but you know, nobody had really heard that really. Sam Most had done some things with, I forget who it was, one of the bands. It might have been Don Redman, I don't know. Because we used to, whenever they would come to watch, and whenever we ran into each other we used to play duets together, you know, and things. But there really wasn't too much of it around, you know. Lot of good flute players, but nobody playing jazz, you know.

MR: We've been interested in seeing if we can give some of our students an idea of what it must have been like to live on the road, and you did a couple of different periods of it.

FW: Yeah.

MR: Yeah, is it all it's cracked up to be or is it—

FW: It's rough. It's like, well in the first place it's physical, you know? And if you're not, if your body's not in good shape you're not really going to make it. Because everything is without a schedule. So you don't eat on time, you don't sleep on time, you don't do anything at the same time. So it's just that kind of life. And sometimes you have to work without sleep and food, you know. It all depends on what happens. The hardest part of it is getting to the gig. After you get there, it's not hard to play but I mean—

MR: Yeah, it's the parts in between, right?

FW: Yeah. Everything that's involved in the transportation and the lodging and all that happens makes it difficult.

MW: What was — relate for us maybe one of your worst experiences on the road or one of your best experiences.

FW: Oh, I can't. I don't know. I really can't remember.

MR: Was there a certain etiquette among the players about getting the solos? How did you decide between you. You and Frank Foster were on the band—

FW: Well that's up to the band leader.

MR: That's up to the band leader?

FW: Yeah. He says you take this and you take that. It's up to him, you know.

MR: What about your writing? Were you writing before the Basie band?

FW: Yeah. Well I've been writing. I think I did my first commercial arrangement in 1940 I think, for the old entertainer, I don't know, you probably never heard of Fifi D'Orsay from Canada. I did an arrangement on "Alouette" for her. Years, years, years ago. And I did a couple of things while I was working with Blanche Calloway. Well I was with Blanche at the time, you know, 1940. So that started. And then all in the service I guess for about, oh four years, I had a band. I had a 17 piece band in the service. And we were overseas quite a while, over three years, way over three years. And our band was always the best band, wherever we went, you know. So we ended up being the General's band, you know, after our first parade that was the order would come out, we were the General's band. And during that time that's when we had just come up from West Africa and we went, I mean I was assistant band leader and the band leader and I went down to Special Service, you know, to see what they had for the band. Because we were regular Army. And we found out that there was, they were getting a tour together for Josephine Baker. So we put our name down, and Josephine came out and auditioned the band. And we played a few of our things and she said, "let's see how you do with my things," you know so we did that. There was a lull in my life, and then I remember I had to conduct [sounds like] Felic Adiss. So we did that, and she said "you got it." So we toured all around North Africa with Josephine Baker.

MR: This is while you're still in the service?

FW: Yeah.

MR: Yeah? That must have been—

FW: Well we had a big band. We had special authorization for 55 pieces, and the Army band was only 28. But our band leader was a friend of President Roosevelt's. So we had special authorization and he used to recruit professional musicians who were on the road and about to be drafted. And he had a deal where if you came into the band with him, you didn't have to take any basic training, and you got a rating the first day you came in. So you know, we never did anything but play music. That was it. So we didn't have to go through all that other stuff.

MR: And how many years did you spend with Basie?

FW: Well, over eleven.

MR: Yeah?

FW: Yeah. Milt Hinton and I joined the band the same day.

MR: I'll be darned. We've been trying to get different people's different takes on what made the Basie rhythm section the Basie rhythm section. It's like a term in jazz, you know? And what was that?

FW: Basie did. Yeah, it was Basie's rhythm section.

MR: Was it his direction?

FW: It was his style of playing, you know, that did it. He had a way of being effective, you know without being overpowering, you know, without playing too much. Most pianists would, with that type of band, they'd try to play too much when it's really not necessary. Because you see you had the guitar keeping the rhythm already, you know, you don't need it, so it's up to you to complement what's being played in the band and enhance it in a way, you know, that's not what, you get a piano player, he wants to be a piano player. But you don't need a piano player, you know what I mean? You need a musician that knows how to complement the band. So that's what Basie was better than good at. He was the master of that.

MW: Can you tell us anything about or contrast for us, what they call the riff style, that they played in the bands in the southwest, as compared to the big bands on the east coast.

FW: I don't know what that is. I don't know. I don't know, people name things, I don't know what it is.

MR: I guess they call it the Kansas City style of creating riffs and so forth.

FW: Oh, you mean for arrangements?

MR: Yeah.

FW: Well that's, bands, they've done that. All bands, most bands when they first start out, you know they start out like that because they don't have any music, so you've got to start like that, you know. When I was with Billy Eckstine's band, it started out the same way, you know. You start out, you've got two or three arrangements and you've got to do a job four or five hours, and you've got to have a book so you make up music as you go. That arrangement on "Every Day" that Joe Williams did, the band was playing it a head. When Joe Williams came in the band, he didn't have no music. Basie played the introduction and we started playing the music. And Ernie Wilkins just put an introduction on it, and copied just what we played, he wrote just what we played.

MR: That's great. That's like arranging in reverse almost.

FW: Well that's the way it is always. Music is always played before it's written. So it's usually that's the reason when you see something written a certain way, whoever wrote it meant for it to sound the way he heard it. See because it comes from the playing, not the writing to the playing, from the playing to the writing. That's the way it usually goes.

MW: You know they also say that is true with the arrangers. The arrangers basically they say listen to the soloist.

FW: That's what I mean. Yeah. That's what I mean. Yeah. They hear it, and then they write it.

MR: What was it like playing in different parts of the world with the Basie band?

FW: Oh, we always had a good following. And the band was hot. We were in one of the best bands Basie ever had. And that's the band that made him rich, you know. The band was tight. I had forgotten actually, how good the band was until I was listening to those Mosaic recordings. And then it came back to me, how good that band was. It was like one person playing, you know. Everybody was—it was a good band. Well Basie, he knew how to do that. You know he didn't fault nobody. He just let it stay there until the cats got it together, and then when they got it together he knew what to do with it. But you know the fellows in the band did all of that. He didn't know too many people, really, I mean musicians. When he'd want somebody, you know he'd say, "hey Magic, I need a trumpet player—I need a trombone player—I need a bass"—I need this—I need that. And I'd tell him who to call. I got Eddie Jones in the band, Bill Hughes, Sonny Cohn, Eric Dixon, Thad Jones, I can't think, oh Al Aarons. Yeah I got a whole lot of people in the band, you know. And when I left I recommended Danny Turner but he didn't know Danny so he didn't know that Danny could play lead, so he got Bobby Plater. He knew Bobby Plater could play lead. But I recommended Danny Turner to him when I left.

MR: Were you happy switching from the tenor to the alto?

FW: It didn't make much difference. But I would have made a lot more money if I'd have quit then. Yeah, if I'd have left. Because things were more busy in New York you know. And then, but as it turned out it was all right. Because New York wasn't as busy when I quit five years later, but I made the transition without raising the pay.

MR: Into the studios?

FW: Yeah and into Broadway. Yeah and studio work. I went from one thing to the other without missing a payday. But if I'd quit earlier, I would have made a lot more money because there was a lot more things happening in New York at that time, commercially you know.

MW: How do you feel that the studio work was different from the big band playing?

FW: Oh, well you know, this is a different ball game altogether, because when you're playing creative music, jazz, you know your identity is important. But when you're playing commercial music, you have to sacrifice your identity to sound like everybody else. So it's a different thing altogether.

MR: Have you noticed when Basie was recording did they ever, there were certain times when you might have done like there was a Broadway record I think that was done? How did he fit into the changing times?

FW: I wasn't there then. See I've been away from the band over 30 years. So by the time he started doing that I wasn't around.

MR: Right.

FW: Yeah, I told him to call Eric because you know I was playing third alto, and he put me there because he knew I could play first if Marshall wasn't there, you know, he always kept somebody in the third chair that could play lead, so that he would never be without a lead player, you know. So he kept changing, looking for a tenor player, and it was bugging me, you know, because I'd played the book for what five or six years, you know what I mean? I knew what it was supposed to be. And he got all these people coming and I says "man, look, you better get you a tenor player." He says, "Who can I call?" I says, "call Eric Dixon." So he called him and he stayed there.

MR: Who were some of your favorite drummers and bass players during that period?

FW: Oh, Kenny Clarke. Now you mean with Basie band?

MR: Yeah.

FW: Well there were only two, Gus Johnson and Gus Johnson got sick so we were trying out different drummers, and they didn't make it. He even called Papa Jo back, but Papa Jo didn't fit with that band you know, it was a different thing. So one day he says, "hey Magic, come over, I got a little drummer down here, let's go catch him." So we went down to the Regal Theater in Chicago, me and Bas', and Sonny Payne was there with I think maybe Erskine Hawkins or somebody. And he say, "What you think, man?" I say, "Yeah, he can make it." So eventually he got Sonny and Joe Williams came in at the same time you know. So that's when, the band really started to get together you know. Before that I mean when I joined the band, I thought, I said, this is the saddest band I've ever played with in my life. Well it was the situation you know that we were in. We had to do two weeks in the Band Box, opposite Duke Ellington. And you know what I mean.

MR: Some competition?

FW: That ain't no competition, we were out of the park, we weren't even in it. We used to listen, Benny Powell and I used to listen to tapes from that band, boy we'd listen to those tapes and laugh, 'cause the band was so sad it was funny, you know. And Duke was fired up. But we had a lot of spirit, but that was all. The band was just sad that's all. That was funny. Another time I was really embarrassed. I was working with this dance hall band and I was, I guess 16 or 17 years old, something like that. And this band leader he looked to battle music with our band, and Glen Gray and the Casaloma in Griffiths Stadium. I've never been so embarrassed in all my life. It was really, really depressing.

MR: Glen Gray, he was a pretty popular group at the time. Right?

FW: Oh, yeah, yeah. They were hot, and in tails, and all this shit. And we were just a chump, I guess about 13, about 12 or 13 piece band. Really embarrassing.

MR: How did you guys all get your nicknames?

FW: Oh, I don't know. I've had a million of them.

MW: I wanted to ask you. You know you did study technically, but can you relate to us how you feel like the bands themselves were little universities?

FW: Oh, yeah. Well that's always, you always try to surround yourself with the best, you know. You always want to play with somebody that's better than you, and some people are just more compatible than others. I mean they can all be great but they still have to be compatible musically. So when you get you know a situation where the chemistry is right and the people are compatible and they know what they're doing, and then they bring in you know styles and information and experience from different places, so it works together. And then they have a mutual respect for each other, you know, musically.

MW: Could you relate to us how you know for instance I see bands play and it seems like there's certain amounts of unspoken communication going on on the stage. I mean all the musicians are competent and they know the changes, but there are special nights, special times during a performance sometimes when unspoken communication takes place.

FW: Well if you catch a band and people that live together, you know, and that's the way you're going to have a band. Otherwise you've just got a lot of good musicians together. But if people live together and you know they move together and travel together, they, you know, it's a lot of little inside things that happen, you know and so, that always goes on too you know. But that just comes from being together.

MR: What would you say to our young musicians about the blues?

FW: What do you mean about the blues?

MR: Well, we've had some—

FW: Try and make them turn green. That's the best thing I can tell you.

MR: As a form of music, was it, when were you aware of learning—is it something that you played on early in your career as an improviser?

FW: Yeah, well you know, I came up in the southwest. It's something you come up with just like anything else, like water. You can understand. And there was a lot of that influence came from blues singers and guitar players and sounds. Like all from things in Africa, it comes from field sounds and in this country a lot of things used to come from train sounds, train whistles. And as you know, you could always tell who the engineer was by the way he blew the whistle. So a lot of that comes from sounds that you hear in the environment. They all come. And guitar players imitate blues singers, and it all gets incorporated in the music. It's a way of life. And that's what it is. The only thing that I would say to all students I mean is that you have to study and be efficient technically, and you know you have to have endurance and there is so much that you have to do for so long. But really, a lot of that isn't music, you know?

MW: It's more like calisthenics?

FW: No, they're etudes. And etudes are studies and that's what they were meant to be, and that's what they are. Because you can't consider most etudes as music, because they're not. You know they were designed to do a certain thing. Technically you know. But you know most students, they spend so much time doing that that when they come out and start playing they think they're making music when it's got nothing to do with that. It's two different things. I can be the greatest saxophone player in the world and not be able to make a note of music. It's two different things. See so they have to get, they almost have to forget that.

MW: Learn it.

FW: And forget it. And then make some music, you know what I mean? Because it's been my observation that all good music, regardless of what type it is, European music or I don't care, any kind of music, it's all a matter of, well it's an extension actually of us. And we, as a part of the universe, we operate the same way. It's a matter of tension and release. And in music it's the same thing, you see what I mean? And in the best music, I've noticed it's the artful use of that tension and release that makes the music, using the components of music which are first rhythm, because you can have rhythm without melody, and melody and harmony, and the one that's ignored so much — which is this is important — is silence. Because that is the ultimate release to sound. And it's the silence that makes the sound important. So if you keep on playing, it gets to be more and more meaningless as you go. So you have to—

MR: I guess Basie was a good example of that.

FW: Oh, yeah, well it's a matter of communicating as opposed to self gratification, you know, which is not nice in public. So kids, you know, they gradually grow out of that, but some of them naturally understand that, but I mean there are some, quite a few that don't. They're so wrapped up in playing the instrument and the patterns and all the things that they've learned and trying to get out there, you know what I mean, they forget about they're supposed to be making music and communicating, which is an entirely different thing. Some cats could do more with, like our old cats, they didn't have, they didn't use all the complex harmonies that we use today. They'd build a better house with just a hammer and a nail than you did with all the electric saws and stuff. So it's a matter of making music. It's got nothing to do with all that other stuff. So that's what students should really think about you know.

MR: That's the hardest thing to teach too.

FW: You know you can't teach that, music is, well the only thing you can do, somebody that has potential, you just have to make them aware of that. You can't teach them that. You

make them aware of that and then they handle it in their way. You can't teach anybody that. You can put it there, but as far as teaching it, that's another thing.

MW: You can coach but you can't—

FW: Yeah, yeah, yeah.

MR: I think it has a lot to do with how much they've listened to as they grow up and their experience too.

FW: Yeah, yeah, yeah well you're wondering how much they listen to every day, you know? You have to listen to, and I think there's a lot of things you shouldn't listen to. Because you are influenced by whatever you hear, I mean whether you like it or not, you know so there's just so many things that you shouldn't even listen to. Because everything you hear over the radio ain't the Gospel, and everything you read in the paper ain't the Gospel. Those people are making deadlines and making money, that's what is actually the fact.

MW: In fact, someone was talking to me about that one day and I told them I said I think we live in a tabloid society.

FW: Yeah, well that's what you know people are making it. And they don't even bother to get the facts. All they had to do was ask somebody that knows, you know, and it was just a [inaudible]. Some kind of critic in Japan wrote an article on me and said I worked in the post office for years before I joined Basie. Well you know, that's, maybe someone told him that, I don't know. But he didn't bother to find out. He was just making a deadline so he writes it. And then you know as a matter of fact, people write stories, the editing, because people, without knowing it, can put things in a different context, the way they understand it. But that's got nothing to do with what I meant. You know that's the reason I don't give interviews, because so many times I've talked to somebody and then when I read what they said it's got nothing to do with what I was saying. But it was from their point of view, maybe they want to make it sensational or something.

MR: Or if they chop off the whole part leading up to that.

FW: Yeah, yeah, yeah, yeah, then it is a whole different thing you see? You can't edit stuff. Just because you don't understand it the way I say it, don't mean that you can change it the way you want it. Some chick came up to me she was writing a book about Joe Williams, and she felt that she needed something sensational in the book. So she comes to me and says, "I heard you drew a knife on Sonny Payne's girlfriend" and you know what the hell is that? But you know she wanted something, you know, to spice up her book. I say you can write it if you want to, but you can talk to my lawyer. Ridiculous. But they don't care, not really.

MW: And then another thing that, that bothers you about that is that has nothing to do with the quality of the music, the art form, or the cultural context.

FW: That's right. Well they don't care about that. They're making a deadline that's what it is. And I've seen a lot of the better known critics come and say, "Hey Frank, did you hear Diz? Yeah who's with him? How'd he sound" Like I ain't got time to get over there, but "Was it all right?" They've just got so much work to do they haven't got time to cover everything he's got to cover and he's got to get the article out. But people believe what they read, which is not good. Because a lot of it has got nothing to do with what's going on.

MW: You know this is something that one of the other musicians that we interviewed talked about. He said it's important to hear this music live.

FW: Yes it is.

MW: And the reason why I'd sort of like you to elaborate on this is, when I hear something live, I make an immediate value judgment about how that music is effecting me. When the artist finishes a piece, if I really enjoy that piece, I clap my hands. And because that music moved me, I was participating in the moment with what that person was playing or saying.

FW: Well that's what it's about. It's communication. And you feel that. And people feel that when the music is being made in front of them. It's like watching somebody cook a dish. You know you put some of this in and some of that. And people can tell when it's not contrived, it's when you're actually doing it on the spot. But people can tell that. And they enjoy that. I mean mistakes and all, they enjoy it because it's natural.

MR: Yeah, it's what the creation is all about.

FW: It would be much better if the recording engineers would come out in the room and hear the music they're trying to record before they listen over those speakers, you know. Because most of them don't have the slightest idea of what they're recording. You know all they hear is what comes over that speaker. They don't ever come out in the room and listen to the band, to really hear what's going on. And so I'd like to get them out there too. They've got to see that.

MR: And move away from their knobs.

FW: Yeah. That's their security blanket. But actually it's really gotten—and you know if you're going to make an authentic reproduction of something, you have to know what you're trying to reproduce.

MW: Know what the real thing sounds like.

FW: That's right.

MW: Before you try to work with what the mechanized thing sounds like.

FW: But that's our business, so we have to suffer that a lot of times.

MR: Well, we've had some great insights from our guest today, and we know you have to perform tonight.

FW: Yes. I hope it will be better than the other night. I was so tired I couldn't —

MW: Sounded good to me, I was there.

FW: Well you know I'd been up all day, I got about four hours sleep and got up at 7:00 and went on, you know all day, and then 10:00 at night you've got to be beautiful.

MR: Yeah, you're on now.

FW: Well, everybody was tired.

MR: Well you've got a good band with you, that's nice.

FW: Well I tried to make sure that the sound was right before we started. So I went out in the room to hear myself, because that's another thing, you can't trust sound men. You can not. I don't care where they are — Carnegie Hall or anyplace else. You can not trust them because they—

MR: They have their own agenda.

FW: Yeah, which has got nothing to do with—

MW: Or they have their own concept of what they think you sound like.

FW: That's right. And they don't know, you know, they really don't. And then when it gets messed up then they start, you know, or if they get excited by the music they start changing. And they want to take all control. If you want to play soft, they'll turn you up. You want to play loud, oh, that's too loud, they turn you down. What the hell is that. Well that's really I like Phil Wood's idea of playing acoustic. Then you don't have to bother with that. But that's what happens.

MR: Well I'm going to say thanks to Frank Wess on behalf of the Hamilton Jazz Archive. And I appreciate your thoughts with us today.

FW: My pleasure.

MR: Thank you very much.

MW: Thank you.